



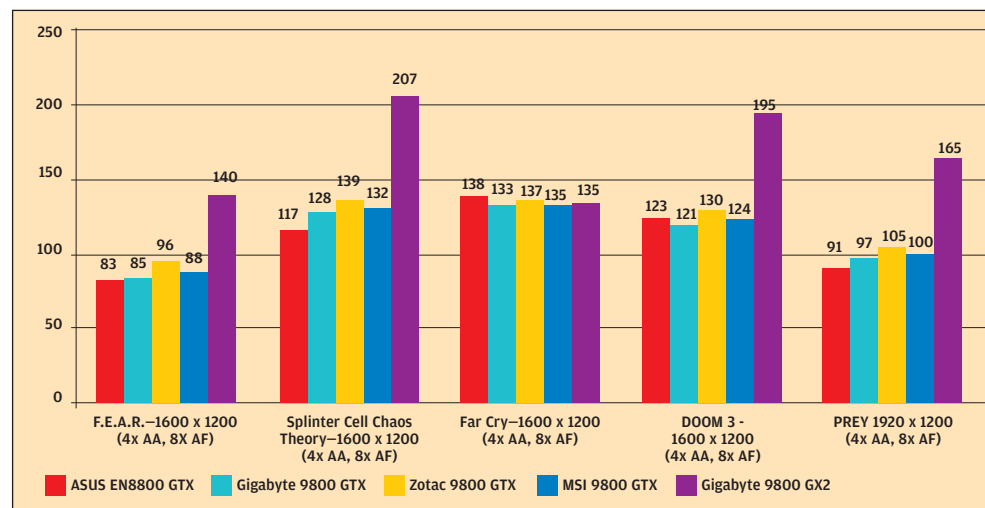
Geforce 9 Series GTX Unleashed!

8800GTxs In Trimmed Sheep Clothing

NVIDIA continues to blast away its competition with the 9 series. The first wave of attack was done by the latest excellent value for money cards—the 9600GT which we tested last month. They were almost as good at performance as the 8800GT for around an 85 per cent of the price, but they ran cooler and consumed a little less power. The 8 series of cards were led by the 8800GTX, but the 9800GTXs are finally here. We have here three GeForce 9800GTX's from three different companies—Gigabyte, MSI and ZOTAC.

While three share the same design and cooler, the ZOTAC's Amp! Edition and MSI are overclocked. The MSI runs at a core speed of 700 MHz and the ZOTAC at 750 MHz! All the cards came with 512 MB of GDDR3 RAM.

NVIDIA doesn't seem to be in any hurry to jump onto the DirectX 10.1 bandwagon—the 9800GTX, like the 9600GT, is also a DirectX 10 card. It is turning out to be a good decision, with most current games still continuing



to release with DirectX 9 support.

The coolers on the 9800GTXs look a lot like the stock 8800GTS 512 coolers. The cards need two 6-pin connectors to power them and the cards occupy two slots.

Throughout all the tests, the Gigabyte 9800GTX was lagging a little behind the MSI, while slightly ahead of the Zotac. The Zotac's 9800GTX's extra power is most visible in the Splinter Cell Chaos Theory benchmark. Games perform equally well, even



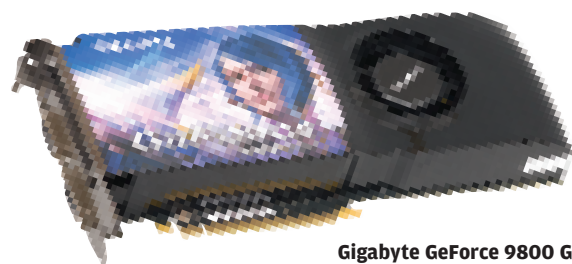
MSI N9800 GTX

after pushing the resolution up to 1600 x 1200 at maximum quality with anti-aliasing and anti-stropic filtering turned up to the maximum.

The 9800GTX isn't the new benchmark for high-end cards. It then appears that the 9800GTX is nothing

more than a refined and matured 8800GTX, just like the 9600GT was, as compared to the 8800GT. All the cards we received performed the same way as some of the better 8800GTXs we've seen. They are only a bit cooler and more power efficient

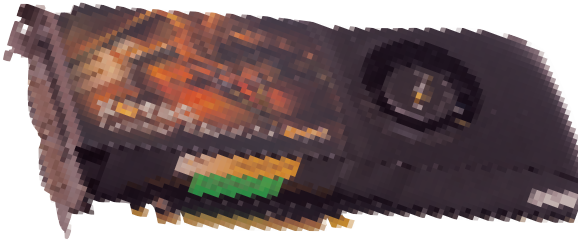
Ratings and Contacts	Gigabyte	MSI	Zotac
	GeForce 9800 GTX—GV-NX98X512H-B	GeForce 9800GTX—N9800GTX-T2D512-OC	GeForce 9800GTX Amp! Edition
Features	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Value For Money	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Price	Rs 20,500	Rs 21,500	Rs 24,999
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Gigabyte GeForce 9800 GTX

mainly because of the move to 65-nm fabrication process. The 9800GTX also supports HybridPower, which allows the card to be completely shut down if run on NVIDIA's HybridPower-supported motherboards. The most significant differ-

ence is that the 9800GTX is a lot cheaper than the 8800GTXs were when they were launched. So, there is no reason whatsoever for an 8800GTX user to upgrade to the 9800GTX. If at all an upgrade is needed, a 9800GX2 could be thought



Zotac GeForce 9800 GTX

of. We have tested a Gigabyte 9800GX2 this month too. The 8800GTX's were Rs 6000 to Rs 8000 costlier when they arrived.

Of the three cards we tested, the Gigabyte was the slowest, but it still makes great value for

money. The overclocked MSI and Zotac 9800GTX's result in only a mere 5 to 10 fps improvement over the Gigabyte. For such boost, ZOTAC sets you back by Rs 4,500 and the MSI, which was the next best, costs Rs 1,000 more.

Cooler Master NotePal W2

Try Something, Accomplish Something Else!

The NotePal W2 from CoolerMaster is a notebook cooler designed to tackle heating issues associated with laptops. We put it through punishment for a month and it comes off with flying colours on many fronts.

The cooler is made out of aluminium, with three holes in the centre, which are covered with a steel mesh. Behind the steel mesh are three 1500 RPM sleeve-bearing fans for ventilation. The laptop sits on the top surface. The surface is concave, thus leaving room for the fans to circulate air between the hot laptop and the aluminium surface.

The aluminium surface is at an angle, which dramatically improves ergonomics when using the notebook on a desk. The relative angle between the laptop keyboard, eyes and the screen becomes more comfortable and reduces strain on the wrists and neck. Our reviewer, who uses his laptop on a daily



basis, noted this after using the NotePal W2 for a little over a month.

On the cooling front, we didn't see any perceptible difference. However, in notebooks with venting on the back, the fans do help in lowering the temperature, but slightly! The fans draw power from the laptop's USB port. However, the USB hub on the NotePal ensures you don't lose any ports. The fans can be switched off via the power button—pretty

useful if you are sitting in an air-conditioned room.

The NotePal W2 is sturdy, well finished and comes in three colour options—Silver, Black and Titanium. Priced sensibly at Rs 1,400, we recommend it more for its ergonomic advantages than cooling.

Specifications:

Two USB Ports, Dimensions: 40 x 30.8 x 5.1 cm, Fan speed: 1500 RPM +/- 20%, Noise: 21 dBA, Current: 0.1 A, Supports

17-inch laptops including widescreen

Contact: Cooler Master
Phone: 9833870302
E-mail: Tanmay_L@Coolermaster.com
Web site: www.coolermaster.com
Price: Rs 1,400

RATINGS

Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★